

COFFEE

ESPRESSO	2.50
AMERICANO	2.75
CAPPUCCINO	3.25
LATTE	3.25
MOCHA	3.25
CHAI LATTE	3.50
ICED COFFEE	2.75
LOOSE LEAF TEA	3.00

COFFEE
&
CHAOS

Barista Goes Down

*How a quiet
girlfriend became
a cheating girlfriend*

EVAN SLATE

BARISTA GOES DOWN

How a quiet girlfriend became a cheating
girlfriend

Evan Slate

PMI

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I was wiping down the espresso machine when I felt Aden watching me. I knew it wasn't the first time that shift. But this time I looked up and caught his eyes for half a second before he turned back to the register.

I told myself it was nothing.

My boyfriend Terry got me this job three weeks ago because he thought it would be good for me. He said it over dinner one night, his hand warm on my knee, his voice soft and careful like he was suggesting therapy instead of a part-time gig at his friend's cafe. He thought the social environment would pull me out of my shell, help me become the expressive person he was convinced was hiding somewhere inside me.

I didn't have the heart to tell him that maybe there wasn't anyone hiding. Maybe I was just a quiet girl. Maybe that was all there was to me.

But I'd said yes anyway because saying no to Terry was impossible. He wanted things for me more than I wanted them for myself, and that kind of love made me feel guilty and grateful in equal measure. So I showed up to Driftwood on a Thursday morning wearing black jeans and a nervous smile. Aden had looked up from grinding beans and said, "You must be Brenna."

I nodded and managed something like "nice to meet you." I let him show me how to work the register and steam milk and wipe down tables between rushes. He was patient without being condescending, and he didn't push me to talk when I went quiet. That first shift I thought maybe Terry had been right. Maybe this would be fine. Maybe I could do this.

The moment I started noticing Aden differently came during my second week. I'd been reaching for a bag of coffee beans on the top shelf, standing on my toes, my shirt riding up, and when I turned around he was right there, close enough that I could smell him. He stepped back immediately, hands up, apologetic, but his eyes flicked down for just a second. It happened so quickly I almost missed it, but I didn't miss it. My breath caught in my throat before I could stop it.

"Sorry," he said. "Didn't mean to crowd you."

I shook my head, said it was fine, moved past him with my heart beating too fast.

That night I went home to Terry and let him kiss me on the couch and ask about my day, and I told him it was all good. Busy. Aden was a good teacher. All of it true. But none of it the whole truth.

Now it was Friday night, almost closing time, and the cafe was empty except for the two of us.

Aden was in the back doing inventory while I finished the last of the closing tasks. I could hear him moving around, the soft thud of boxes being shifted, the scratch of his pen on the clipboard. The cafe felt different when it was empty like this. Smaller somehow. The low amber lighting made everything softer, warmer. More intimate.

I focused on stacking chairs, trying to ignore the awareness prickling along my spine. Terry would be home by now, probably wondering when I'd be back. My shift had technically ended twenty minutes ago, but Aden asked if I could stay a bit to help with inventory since the other girl had called in sick. I texted Terry that I'd be late. He sent back a thumbs up and a heart.

All I felt was the flutter in my chest every time I heard Aden's footsteps getting closer to the doorway.

"You good out here?" His voice came from behind me, low and easy.

I turned, still holding a chair. "Almost done."

He leaned against the doorframe, arms crossed, watching me work. He did that sometimes, just watched, and I never knew if I was supposed to say something or keep going like I didn't notice. Today I kept going. I set the chair down, moved to the next table, aware of every movement I made, aware of how my jeans fit, how my hair fell over my shoulder when I bent forward. Aware of him being aware.

"You're getting faster at closing," he said.

"Practice."

"Terry says you're really enjoying it here."

I paused, cloth in hand. "You talk to Terry about me?"

"Sometimes. He asks how you're doing. Wants to make sure I'm not working you too hard." Aden smiled. "He cares about you a lot."

The words landed heavy. I turned back to the table, spraying cleaner, wiping in slow circles. "I know he does."

"He's a good guy."

"Yeah."

The silence hung between us. I could feel him still watching. I wiped the same table three times before I realized what I was doing and forced myself to move on.

"You don't talk much, do you?" Aden said finally.

"Not really."

"Is that just how you are, or is it me?"

I looked up at him then, surprised by the directness. His expression was open, curious, not pushing but genuinely asking. It would have been easy to deflect, to say something about being shy or tired. Instead I heard myself say, "I don't know yet."

Something shifted in his face. Not a smile exactly, but close. "Fair."

He pushed off the doorframe and walked toward me until he was a few feet away. He picked up the last chair from the table I was working on and flipped it up onto the surface with an easy motion. His arm brushed past me as he did it. The touch was so brief it might have been accidental, but my skin registered it like a spark.

"I'll finish these," he said. "You can start on the counter if you want."

I nodded and moved away, putting space between us, trying to steady my breathing. At the counter I began organizing the syrups, lining them up by flavor, focusing hard on the small task to keep my mind from wandering. But I could still feel where his arm had grazed mine. I could still smell the faint cedar scent when he got close.

It was ridiculous. I was being ridiculous. He was my boyfriend's friend. He given me a job as a favor, and I was standing here reading into every accidental touch like some desperate teenager.

"Brenna."

I turned. Aden was closer than I expected, standing just on the other side of the counter. The register sat between us like a barrier.

"Yeah?"

"You seem tense. Is everything okay?"

My mouth went dry. "I'm fine."

"You sure? Because if the job's too much, or if I'm doing something that makes you uncomfortable, you can tell me. Terry would kill me if I stressed you out."

There it was again. Terry's name. A reminder. A boundary. But the way Aden was looking at me didn't feel like a friend checking in on his buddy's

girlfriend. It felt like something else entirely, something that made my pulse jump and my thighs press together.

"You're not stressing me out," I said quietly.

"That's good." He held my gaze for a beat longer. "I want you to feel comfortable here."

"I do."

"Do you?"

The question hung in the air between us. I stood there, fingers gripping the edge of the counter while something unspoken stretched tight as a wire.

Aden broke first. He stepped back, ran a hand through his hair, glanced toward the windows. "It's late. You should probably head home. I can finish up."

"I don't mind staying."

The words came out before I could stop them. They sounded too quick, too eager. I saw the flicker of something in his expression, there and gone in a second.

"Terry's probably waiting for you," he said.

"He's fine. He knows I'm helping close."

Aden studied me for a moment, like he was trying to figure out what I wasn't saying. Then he nodded slowly. "Alright. Come help me in the back then. Inventory goes faster with two people."

The back room was cramped, lit by a single fluorescent tube that buzzed overhead. Shelves lined the walls, stacked with boxes of coffee beans, filters, paper cups, all the everyday necessities of running a cafe. There was barely enough room for two people to move around without bumping into each other.

Aden handed me the clipboard. "Call out what's on the list and I'll count what we have."

I took it, trying to focus on the inventory sheet instead of how small the space felt with both of us in it. "Espresso beans, dark roast."

He crouched down to check the bottom shelf, his back to me. I let myself look at him properly for the first time all night, the way his shoulders filled out his shirt, the line of his neck, the easy confidence in how he moved, like he was comfortable in his own skin in a way I'd never been in mine.

"Four bags," he said, standing.

I wrote it down. "Medium roast."

He turned to the shelf behind me, and suddenly we were face to face in the narrow space between the storage racks. I didn't move, and neither did he.

"Excuse me," he said softly.

I pressed back against the shelf, but there still wasn't enough space. He had to turn sideways to get past me, his chest brushing my shoulder, his hand steadying himself on the shelf above my head. The closeness made my breath catch. I could feel the heat coming off his body. I could smell that cedar scent again, stronger now.

He paused there, half-turned, his face inches from mine.

Neither of us moved.

The fluorescent light buzzed. My heart hammered against my ribs. I could see the exact moment he registered how I was looking at him, because his expression changed. It darkened. His eyes dropped to my mouth, then back up.

"Brenna," he said, and my name in his voice sounded different than it had before.

I should have reminded him that I had a boyfriend, and that the boyfriend was his friend. That this was wildly inappropriate.

Instead I whispered, "Yeah?"

He didn't answer. Just looked at me like he was trying to decide something. Then he stepped back putting distance between us, and turned to the shelf to count the bags with his jaw tight.

"Six," he said, his voice rougher than before.

I wrote it down with shaking hands.

We finished the inventory in near silence, both of us careful not to get too close again, both of us pretending that moment hadn't happened. But it had happened. And when I finally left twenty minutes later, walking out into the cool night air with my bag slung over my shoulder, I could still feel the ghost of his presence in that cramped back room.

My phone buzzed as I unlocked my car. Terry.

How was closing? Want me to order food?

I stared at the message for a long moment before typing back.

It was fine. Yeah, order something. Be home soon.

I sat in the driver's seat, hands on the wheel, engine off, and let myself admit what I'd been denying all night.

I wanted Aden.

Not in some vague, harmless way. I wanted him in a way that made my skin feel tight and my thoughts go places they had no business going. I wanted to know what his hands would feel like on me. What his mouth would taste like. What sounds he made if I touched him the way I'd been imagining.

The guilt crashed over me then, sharp and sudden. Terry was at home right now ordering us dinner, being sweet and thoughtful, completely unaware that his girlfriend was sitting in a parking lot outside his friend's cafe having thoughts that would destroy him.

I started the car and drove home, and the whole way there I told myself it was just a passing thing. Just attraction. Just biology. It didn't mean anything. I wouldn't act on it.

But I was already lying to myself, and somewhere deep down I knew it.

I didn't work at Driftwood again until Wednesday. Terry had plans with friends Tuesday night and suggested I pick up a shift, but I'd told him I was tired. The truth was I needed distance. I needed time to convince myself that what happened in the back room had been nothing. A moment of proximity. A trick of lighting. It was just my imagination running wild because I'd been cooped up too long.

By Wednesday morning I'd almost believed it.

Then I walked into Driftwood and saw Aden behind the counter, and everything I'd carefully constructed over the past few days crumbled. He looked up when the bell chimed, and our eyes met, and I felt it again. That pull. That heat low in my stomach that had nothing to do with coffee or friendship or professional courtesy.

"Hey," he said. "Wasn't sure you'd be in today."

"I'm on the schedule."

"I know. I just thought maybe you'd want to switch after working Friday." He wiped down the espresso machine, not quite looking at me. "Long closing shifts can be rough."

I set my bag behind the counter and tied on my apron. "It was fine."

"Yeah?"

"Yeah."

The morning rush started before we could say anything else. For two hours we moved around each other in the practiced dance of coworkers who'd learned each other's rhythms. I took orders while he made drinks. He called out names while I wiped down tables. We didn't talk beyond what

was necessary. Didn't touch. Didn't even make eye contact more than we had to.

But I was aware of him every single second. I was aware of his hands on the espresso machine. Aware of the way his shirt pulled across his shoulders when he reached for the high shelf. Aware of his voice cutting through the noise of the grinder to call out "Brenna, need more oat milk up front" like my name was just another item on a checklist.

It wasn't until almost noon, when the rush finally died down and we had a moment to breathe, that he spoke to me directly.

"You seem different today."

I was refilling napkin dispensers, focusing hard on the task. "What do you mean?"

"Quieter. Even for you."

"I'm always quiet."

"Not like this." He came around the counter, leaning against it so he was in my line of sight. "Did I do something Friday night? In the back room?"

My hands went still. "No."

"You sure? Because you've barely looked at me all morning, and I keep thinking maybe I crossed a line or made you uncomfortable or..."

"You didn't," I said, cutting him off. I finally looked up at him. "You didn't do anything wrong."

"Then what's going on?"

Everything. Nothing. I didn't know how to answer without giving myself away, so I just shook my head and went back to the napkins. But Aden didn't move. He stayed there, watching me, until finally he said, "Terry asked me yesterday how you were settling in here."

My chest went tight. "What did you tell him?"

"That you're great. Fast learner. Good with customers even if you don't say much." He paused. "He seemed really happy. Said he'd been worried about you being alone so much."

All I could think was how Terry saw me as a project and Aden saw me as something else entirely.

"He loves you a lot," Aden continued, and there was something careful in how he said it. Like he was testing the weight of the words.

"I know."

"You're lucky. He's a really solid guy."

I set down the napkin dispenser harder than I meant to. "Why do you keep bringing him up?"

Aden's eyebrows rose. "What?"

"Terry. You keep mentioning him. Like I need reminding who I'm dating."

"I didn't mean..."

"I know who my boyfriend is," I said, and my voice came out sharper than I'd intended. "I know he got me this job. I know he's your friend. I know he's a good guy. I don't need you to keep telling me."

The silence that followed was thick and charged. Aden's expression had shifted into something unreadable. He straightened up from the counter, and for a second I thought he was going to walk away. Instead he stepped closer.

"Why are you angry?" His voice was quiet but direct.

"I'm not."

"You are."

I couldn't look at him. I couldn't answer. My heart was pounding too hard and my thoughts were spiraling and all I wanted was for him to stop looking at me like he could see straight through to all the things I was trying to hide.

"Brenna."

I turned away to busy myself with wiping down the counter even though it was already clean. "We should get back to work."

"There's nobody here."

"Someone could come in."

"Then they'll wait a second." He moved into my space again, not touching but close enough that I could feel him. "Talk to me. What's going on?"

"Nothing's going on."

"Bullshit."

The word landed like a slap. I'd never heard Aden swear before. Never heard him be anything but patient and measured and calm. I looked up at him and saw something in his face that matched the chaos inside me.

"You've been different since Friday," he said. "Since the back room. And I need to know if it's because I made you uncomfortable or if it's because..." He stopped himself, jaw working like he was physically holding words back.

"Because what?" My voice came out barely above a whisper.

He held my gaze. "You tell me."

The air between us felt electric. Dangerous. I knew I should lie, laugh it off and deflect and go back to pretending everything was fine. But standing there with him looking at me like that, with the truth sitting heavy on my tongue, I couldn't do it anymore.

"You didn't make me uncomfortable," I said quietly.

"Then what happened?"

I swallowed hard. "I don't think I should answer that."

Something flickered across his face. Recognition maybe. Or confirmation. "Why not?"

"Because." My hands gripped the edge of the counter. "Because Terry's your friend. And my boyfriend. And this is just a job. And I should go back to wiping down tables and you should go back to inventory and we should both forget Friday ever happened."

"Should we?"

"Yes."

"Is that what you want?"

No. God, no. I wanted the opposite. I wanted him to close the distance between us. Wanted to know if the tension I felt was real or just in my head. Wanted things I had no right to want.

"It doesn't matter what I want," I said.

"It matters to me."

The door chimed. We both jumped apart like we'd been caught doing something wrong even though we were just standing there talking. A customer walked in, a middle-aged woman in yoga clothes, completely oblivious to the moment she'd just shattered.

"Hi," Aden said, his voice sliding back into professional politeness so smoothly it was almost jarring. "What can I get you?"

I moved away while he took her order, retreating to the back room on the pretense of getting more cups. My hands shook as I grabbed a sleeve from the shelf. My whole body felt like a live wire. I leaned against the wall and closed my eyes and tried to steady my breathing.

This was getting out of control. Whatever this was, wherever it was going, I needed to stop it before it went too far. I needed to tell Aden we couldn't have conversations like that. I needed to put up boundaries, I

needed to remember that I loved Terry and he loved me and that was supposed to be enough.

But when I walked back out and saw Aden handing the woman her latte, saw him catch my eye over her shoulder with a look that said *we're not done talking about this*, I knew I wasn't going to stop anything.

I was going to let it happen.

The realization settled over me with a strange calm. I wasn't strong enough to fight this. I wasn't good enough to do the right thing. I'd been pretending I was, pretending I could work here and keep everything professional and compartmentalized. But the truth was I'd wanted this from the second week. Maybe even earlier. I'd wanted to feel desired by someone who looked at me like I was more than a project. More than someone to fix.

Aden made me feel visible in a way Terry never had. And that made me a terrible person. But it didn't make it less true.

The woman left with her latte. The cafe was empty again. Aden turned to me.

"I need to ask you something," he said.

I nodded, not trusting my voice.

"And I need you to be honest with me."

"Okay."

He came around the counter slowly until he was standing right in front of me., close enough that I had to tilt my head up to meet his eyes. "Is this just me? Am I reading something that isn't there?"

My mouth went dry. "No."

"No it's not just you, or no you're not reading something?"

"It's not just you."

The confession hung between us. I watched him process it, saw the way his expression shifted from uncertainty to something darker and more certain.

"Fuck," he said quietly.

"Yeah."

"We can't do this."

"I know."

"Terry's my friend."

"I know."

"And you're his girlfriend."

"I know," I said again, and my voice cracked on the word.

Aden ran both hands through his hair, turned away from me, turned back. "So what do we do?"

The question felt impossible to answer. What we should do was obvious. What I was going to do was something else entirely.

"I don't know," I whispered.

He stepped closer by just one step, but it erased what little distance remained between us. "You need to tell me to stop."

"Stop what?"

"This. Because if you don't, I'm going to keep pushing. And we both know where that leads."

My heart hammered against my ribs. Every rational part of my brain was screaming at me to end this right now, to step back and draw the line and save us both from the mistake we were barreling toward.

Instead I heard myself say, "What if I don't want you to stop?"

Aden's expression changed. The careful control slipped and something raw took its place. He looked at me like he was seeing me for the first time and what he saw made his breath catch.

"Brenna," he said, and my name sounded like a warning.

"I should want you to stop," I continued, the words spilling out before I could swallow them back. "I should tell you this is wrong and we need to forget this conversation ever happened. But I can't stop thinking about Friday night. About the back room. About how close you were and how much I wanted you closer."

"Jesus." He took a step back, hands running over his face. "You can't say things like that to me."

"Why not?"

"Because I'm trying really fucking hard to do the right thing here, and you're making it impossible."

I felt something dangerous unfurling inside me. Something that had been locked away for so long I'd forgotten it existed. "What if I don't want you to do the right thing?"

He stared at me. "You don't mean that."

"I do."

"You love Terry."

"That doesn't change what I want right now."

The confession sat between us like something physical. Aden's jaw worked. His hands flexed at his sides. I could see him fighting with himself,

weighing his loyalty to Terry against whatever he was feeling for me.

"We can't," he said finally, but his voice lacked conviction.

"I know."

"If we do this, there's no going back."

"I know that too."

"Then why..." He cut himself off, shaking his head. "Why are you doing this?"

I didn't have a good answer. I didn't have any answer except the truth. "Because you look at me and see someone I don't even recognize. Someone who isn't quiet or withdrawn or broken. And when I'm around you I feel like maybe that person actually exists."

Something in his face softened. "You're not broken, Brenna."

"Terry thinks I am."

"Terry's an idiot."

The bluntness startled me. Aden seemed to realize what he said and grimaced. "That came out wrong. He's not an idiot. He's a good guy. But he doesn't see you. He sees this version of you he wants to fix, wants to draw out. He doesn't realize you don't need fixing."

"And you do?"

"I guess." He moved closer again, and this time he didn't stop until he was right in front of me. "I see exactly who you are. And there's nothing wrong with it."

My breath caught. We were standing so close I could feel the heat radiating off him. I could see the flecks of gold in his eyes. I could smell that cedar scent that had been driving me crazy for weeks.

"Aden," I whispered.

"We should stop talking."

"Probably."

"Someone could walk in."

"Yeah."

Neither of us moved. The space between us felt charged, electric, like the air before a thunderstorm. I could feel my pulse in my throat. Could feel the ache building between my thighs. Could feel every nerve ending in my body straining toward him.

His hand came up slowly, hovering near my face but not quite touching. "Tell me to stop."

I didn't. I couldn't. Instead I leaned forward, closing the distance by millimeters, giving him permission without words.

His fingers brushed my jaw. The touch was feather-light but it sent electricity straight through me. My eyes fluttered closed and I heard the small sound that escaped my throat before I could stop it.

"Fuck," Aden breathed. His thumb traced along my cheekbone, down to my jaw, stopping just short of my mouth. "You're killing me."

"I'm not doing anything."

"That's the problem." His other hand came up to cup my face, tilting it toward him. "You're just standing here looking at me like that and it's taking everything I have not to..."

The bell above the door chimed.

We sprang apart like we'd been electrocuted. Aden turned toward the register, shoulders tense, while I grabbed a cloth and started wiping down the espresso machine with shaking hands. A group of college students tumbled in, laughing and loud, completely oblivious to what they'd interrupted.

I couldn't look at Aden while he took their order. Couldn't trust myself not to give something away. My face felt hot. My hands trembled. Between my legs I was already wet, already aching from nothing more than his fingers on my face.

This was dangerous. This was so far beyond dangerous I didn't even have words for it. But I didn't want to stop. I didn't want to pull back. I wanted to know what would have happened if those students hadn't walked in. I wanted to know what Aden was about to say.

The afternoon dragged out. More customers came in, keeping us busy, keeping us apart. But every time our hands brushed passing cups, every time our eyes met across the counter, every time he said my name, I felt it building, the tension winding tighter and tighter until I thought I might snap from it.

By four o'clock my shift was supposed to end. I untied my apron and reached for my bag, but Aden caught my wrist.

"Stay," he said quietly.

"My shift's over."

"I know. Stay anyway."

I should have said no, walked out that door and never come back, gone home to Terry and confessed everything and begged him to forgive me for

almost betraying him.

Instead I said, "Okay."

Relief flooded his face. "The evening guy called in sick. It'll just be us for closing."

Just us. The words sent a thrill through me that had nothing to do with inventory or mopping floors.

I texted Terry that I was covering a shift. He sent back: *You're so good for helping out. Love you.*

The guilt twisted in my stomach, sharp and immediate. But I set my phone down and tied my apron back on and tried not to think about what I was doing or what I was about to do.

The next two hours passed in a blur. Customers came and went. Aden and I moved around each other with exaggerated care, not trusting ourselves to get too close. But the awareness never faded. Every glance felt loaded. Every word felt like it meant something else.

At six-thirty the last customer left. Aden locked the door and flipped the sign to closed. The click of the lock felt final. Inevitable.

We were alone.

I started clearing tables, trying to focus on the routine of closing tasks. But I could feel Aden watching me from behind the counter. I could feel the weight of all the things we hadn't said pressing down on the space between us.

"Brenna."

I turned. He was leaning against the counter, arms crossed, expression unreadable.

"Yeah?"

"So come here."

It wasn't a request. My feet moved before my brain could intervene, carrying me across the cafe until I was standing in front of him. We were close but not touching. The counter between us like the thinnest of barriers.

"We need to talk about what happens," he said.

"What do you mean?"

"You know what I mean." His eyes held mine. "Because we can stop this right now. You can leave, and we can pretend today didn't happen, and I'll ask Terry to find you a different job somewhere else. Or..."

"Or what?"

He pushed off the counter and came around to my side, eliminating the barrier between us. "Or we admit what this is and deal with the consequences."

My mouth went dry. "And what is this?"

"You tell me." He moved closer, his presence overwhelming. "Because from where I'm standing, it feels like we've been dancing around this for weeks. And I'm tired of pretending I don't want you."

The confession punched the air from my lungs. "Aden..."

"I know it's fucked up," he continued. "I know Terry's my friend and you're his girlfriend and this breaks every rule. But I can't stop thinking about you. Can't stop imagining what you'd feel like. What you'd taste like. What sounds you'd make if I touched you the way I've been wanting to."

Heat flooded through me. My thighs pressed together involuntarily and I saw his eyes track the movement, saw the way his jaw tightened.

"I think about it too," I whispered.

"How often?"

"All the time."

Something dangerous flashed in his eyes. "Show me."

"What?"

"Show me where you think about me touching you."

My heart hammered. This was it. The line. Once I crossed it there was no going back. No pretending this was innocent or accidental. No more lying to myself about what I wanted.

I reached for his hand slowly, giving him time to pull away. He didn't. His fingers were warm when they closed around mine. I brought his hand up, pressed his palm against my chest just above my breast. I let him feel how hard my heart was pounding.

"Here," I said softly. Then I guided his hand lower, over the curve of my breast. My nipple was already hard beneath my shirt and bra. "Here."

His breathing changed. It deepened. His hand stayed where I'd placed it, his thumb brushing over the stiff peak through the fabric. The friction made me gasp.

"Where else?" His voice had gone rough.

I moved his hand down to my stomach. Lower. I stopped just above the waistband of my jeans. "Here."

"Jesus, Brenna." His other hand came up to grip my hip. "If we do this..."

"I know."

"Terry..."

"I know," I said again. "I know it's wrong. I know we shouldn't. But I don't care anymore."

His control finally snapped. He pulled me against him hard, his mouth crashing into mine.

I'd been kissed before. Terry kissed me all the time, sweet kisses, gentle kisses. The kind of kisses that asked permission and waited for permission and never pushed for more than I was ready to give.

This wasn't that.

Aden kissed me like he was starving, like he'd been holding back for weeks and couldn't hold back another second. His mouth was hot and demanding, his tongue sliding against mine with an urgency that made my knees weak. One hand curled in my hair while the other gripped my hip hard enough to bruise, pulling me flush against him until I could feel every inch of his body pressed to mine.

I kissed him back just as desperately. My hands went to his shoulders, his neck, his hair, touching him everywhere I could reach. He tasted like coffee. Heat pooled low in my stomach and spread through my limbs like fire.

He backed me against the counter, his body caging mine in. I felt the hard edge dig into my lower back but I didn't care. I didn't care about anything except the way his mouth moved over mine, the way his hands roamed my body like he'd been mapping it in his mind for weeks.

His lips left mine to trail hot kisses down my jaw, my neck. He found the sensitive spot just below my ear and sucked hard enough to leave a mark. I gasped, my head falling back, my fingers digging into his shoulders.

"Fuck, you taste good," he muttered against my skin. His hand slid under my shirt, palm hot against my stomach, then higher. His thumb brushed the underside of my breast through my bra and I arched into his touch with a sound I barely recognized as my own.

"Aden," I breathed.

He pulled back just enough to look at me. His eyes were dark, pupils blown wide, lips swollen from kissing. "We should stop."

"Don't."

"Someone could see through the windows."

"I don't care."

"Brenna..." But whatever he was going to say died when I pulled him back down to me, kissing him hard enough to cut off the words. I didn't want to think. I didn't want to talk. I didn't want anything except more of this, more of him.

His hand moved higher, cupping my breast fully now, squeezing just hard enough to make me moan into his mouth. My hips rolled forward instinctively, seeking friction, and I felt him hard against my stomach. The knowledge that he wanted me this much sent a rush of power through me.

I reached between us and palmed him through his jeans. He groaned, his hips jerking forward into my touch.

"Jesus Christ," he panted. "We can't do this here."

"Then where?"

He pulled back, chest heaving, looking at me like he was trying to make a decision. "The office. In the back. There's a couch."

The implication of what he was suggesting hit me fully. This wasn't just kissing anymore. This was crossing the final line. This was betraying Terry completely.

I took Aden's hand and let him lead me to the back office.

The room was small, barely more than a closet with a desk and an old couch pushed against one wall. Aden closed the door behind us and flicked on the small lamp in the corner, casting everything in warm amber light.

We stood there for a moment, just looking at each other. The weight of what we were about to do settled over us like something physical. This was real. This was happening.

"We can still stop," Aden said quietly. "I'll understand if you want to leave."

I answered by pulling my shirt over my head and dropping it on the floor.

His eyes went dark. He closed the distance between us in two steps, his hands immediately going to my waist, sliding up my ribs, thumbs brushing the underside of my breasts. "You're sure?"

"Yes."

"Say it again."

"I'm sure." I reached behind me and unhooked my bra, letting it fall. "I want you."

"Fuck." His hands covered my breasts, palms hot against my bare skin. He bent down and took one nipple into his mouth, sucking hard, and I cried

out at the sensation. My fingers tangled in his hair, holding him to me while he lavished attention on first one breast then the other, his tongue circling the sensitive peaks until I was squirming against him.

His hands went to the button of my jeans. He popped it open, dragged down the zipper, and slid his hand inside my underwear.

The first touch of his fingers against me made my legs nearly buckle. I was already so wet, already so worked up from weeks of tension that just that simple contact sent sparks through my whole body.

"God, you're soaked," he muttered against my breast. His fingers explored me slowly, learning what made me gasp, what made my hips jerk forward seeking more. When he found my clit and circled it with just the right pressure, I moaned so loud he had to kiss me to muffle the sound.

"Someone might hear," he said against my mouth.

"I don't care."

His fingers kept moving, kept building that pressure inside me higher and higher. "Terry could call. Could decide to surprise you and show up."

The mention of Terry's name made everything hotter. More forbidden. More wrong in a way that somehow made it feel more intense.

"Don't talk about him," I gasped. "Not right now."

Aden's fingers stilled. "Why not?"

"Because I don't want to think about anything except you." I rolled my hips against his hand.

He groaned and kissed me hard, his fingers resuming their movement. He added a second finger, sliding both inside me, and I broke the kiss to cry out at the fullness. His thumb found my clit while his fingers worked inside me and I felt myself climbing fast toward the edge.

"God you're so hot."

The words pushed me over. My whole body tensed as waves of pleasure rolled through me. I buried my face in his neck to muffle my cries, my hands clutching his shoulders for support while he worked me through it.

When I finally came down, trembling and boneless, he withdrew his hand. I watched through heavy-lidded eyes as he brought his fingers to his mouth and sucked them clean, his eyes never leaving mine.

"I've been wanting to taste you for weeks," he said.

The raw honesty of it sent another pulse of heat through me. I reached for his belt, fumbling with the buckle. "My turn."

He caught my hands. "Not yet."

"Why not?"

"Because once we do this, once we go all the way, there's no pretending it didn't happen. No calling it a mistake or a moment of weakness." His eyes searched mine.

I was sure. Surer than I'd been about anything in months. This was wrong. This was terrible. This was going to hurt people I cared about.

But standing there in that small office with Aden looking at me like I was something precious, something worth ruining a friendship over, I couldn't make myself care about the consequences.

"I'm sure," I said. Then I dropped to my knees in front of him.

His breath caught. "Brenna..."

"Let me." I finished unbuckling his belt and popped the button on his jeans.

He didn't stop me this time. He just watched with dark eyes as I pulled down his zipper and freed him from his boxers. He was hard and thick and the sight of him made my mouth water.

I wrapped my hand around him, stroking slowly from base to tip. He was hot and silky smooth and already leaking at the head. I leaned forward and dragged my tongue across the tip, tasting salt and musk.

"Fuck," he groaned, his hand coming to rest gently in my hair.

I took him into my mouth slowly, savoring the weight of him on my tongue, the way he filled my mouth. I'd done this with Terry before but it had always felt like an obligation. Something I did because he wanted it, not because I craved it.

This was different. I wanted Aden's reactions. I wanted to hear the sounds he made when I sucked hard. I wanted to feel his thighs tense when I took him deeper. I wanted to know I could make him lose control the way he'd just made me lose mine.

I worked him with my mouth and hand together, finding a rhythm that had his breathing going ragged. His fingers tightened in my hair, not forcing but guiding, showing me what he liked.

"Jesus, Brenna," he panted. "Your mouth feels so fucking good."

The praise sent heat straight between my legs. I doubled my efforts, taking him deeper, hollowing my cheeks as I sucked. His hips started to move, shallow thrusts that I encouraged by gripping his ass and pulling him closer.

"I'm close," he warned. "If you don't want..."

I looked up at him and took him even deeper in response. His head fell back with a groan and I felt him pulse in my mouth, hot and thick. I swallowed it all, working him through it until he was shaking.

When I finally pulled off and sat back on my heels, he was staring down at me with something like awe.

"Come here," he said roughly, pulling me to my feet.

He kissed me hard, not caring that he could taste himself on my tongue. His hands were everywhere, urgent and possessive, like he needed to touch every inch of me at once. He walked me backward until my legs hit the couch and I fell onto it with him following me down.

"Take these off," he said, tugging at my jeans.

I lifted my hips and let him peel them down my legs along with my underwear. The air was cool against my overheated skin but I didn't have time to register it before Aden was settling between my thighs, spreading them wide with his hands.

"I need to taste you," he said, his breath hot against my inner thigh.

"You don't have to..."

"I want to." He pressed an open-mouthed kiss to my thigh, then higher. "I've been thinking about this. About how you'd taste. What sounds you'd make."

Then his mouth was on me and coherent thought became impossible.

He wasn't tentative or exploratory. He knew exactly what he was doing, his tongue flat and firm as he licked a long stripe from bottom to top. When he reached my clit he circled it slowly, teasingly, before sucking it into his mouth.

I cried out, my hands flying to his hair. My hips bucked up but he held me down with one strong arm across my lower stomach while his mouth worked magic between my legs. He alternated between broad strokes with his tongue and focused attention on my clit, reading my reactions, learning what made me writhe.

When he added two fingers inside me, curling them just right, I nearly came off the couch. The dual sensation of his mouth and his fingers was overwhelming. Too much and not enough all at once.

"Aden," I gasped. "Oh god, Aden..."

He groaned against me and the vibration sent me spiraling. There was a tightening coil in my lower belly that wound tighter and tighter with every stroke of his tongue. When he added a third finger, stretching me, the

fullness combined with the relentless pressure on my clit pushed me over the edge.

My thighs clamped around his head, my whole body shaking. He didn't let up, working me through wave after wave until I was trembling and oversensitive and pushing weakly at his shoulders.

He finally pulled back, his lips and chin glistening. "You taste even better than I imagined."

I couldn't form words. I could barely breathe. I watched through hazy eyes as he stripped off his shirt, then shoved his jeans and boxers down the rest of the way. His body was lean and toned, all smooth skin and defined muscle. I wanted to touch him everywhere.

He grabbed his jeans from the floor and pulled out his wallet, extracting a condom. The sight of it made everything suddenly, starkly real. This was happening. We were really going to do this.

"Wait," I said.

He froze, condom in hand. "You want to stop?"

"No. I just..." I sat up. "My phone. Terry might text."

Something complicated crossed Aden's face. "Right."

I found my jeans on the floor and pulled out my phone. Three texts from Terry.

How's the shift going?

Want me to pick you up after? We could grab food

Love you babe

The guilt crashed over me in a sickening wave. Terry was at home being sweet and thoughtful while I was here, naked on Aden's couch, about to let his friend fuck me.

"What does he say?" Aden asked quietly.

"He wants to pick me up. Take me to dinner." My voice sounded hollow.

"What are you going to tell him?"

I stared at the screen for a long moment. This was my last chance. I could get dressed right now. Tell Aden this was a mistake. Go home to Terry and pretend this never happened.

Instead I typed: *Shift is running late. Don't wait up. I'll grab something on the way home.*

Then I set the phone on silent and put it face-down on the floor.

When I looked back at Aden, he was watching me with an intensity that made my breath catch.

"You're sure?" he asked one more time.

"Stop asking me that." I reached for him, pulling him down to me. "I'm here. I'm naked. I just came on your face twice. What more do you need?"

A slow smile spread across his face. "When you put it that way."

He rolled on the condom and positioned himself between my legs. I felt the head of him pressing against my entrance and my whole body tensed in anticipation.

He pushed in slowly, giving me time to adjust to the stretch of him. He was bigger than Terry, thicker, and the fullness made me gasp against his mouth. He paused when he was halfway in, his forehead pressed to mine, both of us breathing hard.

"Okay?" he asked.

"Yes. Don't stop."

He pushed in the rest of the way in one smooth thrust and we both groaned at the sensation. He stayed still for a moment, letting me adjust, and I used the time to catalog every sensation. The weight of him above me. The stretch of him inside me. The way his breathing had gone ragged. How different this felt from Terry.

It just made everything hotter.

He pulled out almost all the way and thrust back in, slow and deep. The angle hit something deep inside me that made stars burst behind my eyelids. I wrapped my legs around his waist, urging him deeper, harder.

He found a rhythm that had me gasping with every thrust. Not rough but not gentle either, but purposeful, like he'd been thinking about this as long as I had and was determined to make it everything we'd both been imagining.

"You feel so fucking good," he panted against my neck. "So tight. So perfect."

His words sent heat spiraling through me. I dragged my nails down his back, hard enough to leave marks, claiming him the way he was claiming me. He hissed and thrust harder in response.

"Yes," I moaned. "Like that. Just like that."

He shifted the angle and on the next thrust he hit that spot inside me that made me see white. I cried out and he did it again, and again, until I was writhing beneath him, chasing the building pressure.

"Touch yourself," he commanded. "I want to feel you come around my cock."

The dirty words combined with the authority in his voice nearly undid me right there. I slipped my hand between us and found my clit, rubbing in tight circles while he kept that perfect, devastating rhythm.

"That's it," he groaned. "Fuck, you look so good like this. Taking my cock while you touch yourself. Do you know how many times I've imagined this?"

"Tell me," I gasped.

"Every night." He thrust harder. "Every fucking night I'd lie in bed and imagine what you'd look like under me. What sounds you'd make. How tight you'd feel." Another hard thrust. "I'd stroke myself and picture you just like this, spread out and desperate for it."

The confession sent me over the edge. My whole body went rigid as waves of pleasure crashed through me. I felt myself clench around him, heard myself cry out his name, distantly registered that anyone passing by outside might hear but I couldn't bring myself to care.

He fucked me through it, his rhythm faltering as my body milked him. "Fuck, Brenna, I'm..."

He buried himself deep and his whole body shuddered. I held him through it, my arms around his back, my legs still locked around his waist, feeling every pulse and twitch as he emptied himself inside me.

We stayed like that for a long moment, both of us breathing hard, sweat cooling on our skin. The reality of what we'd just done started to seep in around the edges of the haze.

I'd just cheated on my boyfriend. With his friend. In the back office of a cafe where I was supposed to be working.

Aden lifted his head and looked down at me. Whatever he saw in my face made his expression soften. "Hey. Don't spiral."

"I just..."

"I know." He brushed my hair back from my face. "We both know what this was."

"That doesn't make it okay."

"No. It doesn't." He pulled out gently and I winced at the loss. He disposed of the condom and grabbed his shirt, using it to clean me up with surprising tenderness.

I sat up, suddenly aware of my nakedness, of the situation we'd put ourselves in. My clothes were scattered across the floor. My phone was

face-down where I'd left it, probably full of more messages from Terry by now.

"What do we do?" I asked quietly.

Aden pulled on his boxers and jeans, then sat down next to me on the couch. "I don't know. What do you want to do?"

"I don't know either."

He reached for my hand, lacing his fingers through mine. "Do you regret it?"

When I opened my mouth, what came out was: "No."

His grip on my hand tightened. "Neither do I."

"But Terry..."

"I know." His jaw worked. "He's my friend. I should feel worse about this than I do. But I don't. And I don't think you do either."

He was right. I felt guilty, yes. Felt awful about lying to Terry. But I didn't regret what just happened.

"So what now?" I asked.

Aden turned to face me fully. "That depends. Was this a one-time thing? Something we pretend never happened?"

My heart hammered. "Is that what you want?"

"No." The answer was immediate. "I want this again. I want you again. But only if that's what you want too."

The truth was someone was going to get hurt no matter what I chose. The only question was who.

"I want it too," I whispered.

The drive home felt surreal. My body still hummed with the aftershocks of what we'd done. I could feel the soreness between my legs, a constant reminder of Aden inside me. My lips were swollen from his kisses. There was a mark on my neck I'd have to hide.

There was evidence everywhere.

I felt electric. Alive in a way I hadn't felt in years. Maybe ever.

I pulled into our apartment complex and sat in the car for a moment, checking my reflection in the rearview mirror. My cheeks were flushed. My eyes too bright. I looked different. I looked like I'd been thoroughly fucked, which I had been.

The thought sent a thrill through me that I didn't want to examine too closely.

I tugged my collar higher to hide the mark on my neck and grabbed my bag. My phone showed five more texts from Terry. Sweet messages asking about my day, telling me he missed me, sending me a photo of the neighbor's cat. Normal couple things. The kind of messages I'd gotten a thousand times before.

They felt hollow now. Like they were coming from a stranger.

I let myself into the apartment and found Terry on the couch playing video games. He looked up when I walked in and smiled that easy, trusting smile that used to make me feel safe.

"Hey babe. How was work?"

"Busy." I set my bag down, hyperaware of every movement. "Sorry I'm so late."

"No worries. I saved you some pizza if you're hungry." He paused his game and stood, walking over to kiss me.

I turned my head at the last second so his lips caught my cheek instead of my mouth. "I need to shower first. I smell like coffee and sweat."

"You smell fine to me." He pulled me into a hug and I had to fight the urge to stiffen. His arms around me felt wrong. Like they didn't belong there anymore.

"Long shift," I said against his shoulder. "I'm exhausted."

"Go shower then. I'll warm up the pizza."

I escaped to the bathroom and locked the door behind me. In the mirror I looked at myself properly for the first time. The mark on my neck was darker than I'd thought, a clear bruise just below my ear. My hair was messy. My shirt was wrinkled from being pulled off and tossed on the floor.

I felt a dark thrill looking at the evidence of what I'd done. Aden had marked me. He claimed me in a way that felt primal and possessive. And I'd let him. I wanted him to.

I stripped off my clothes and turned on the shower as hot as I could stand it. Under the spray I touched myself where Aden had touched me. Where his mouth had been. Where he'd been inside me. My body responded immediately, heat pooling low in my belly.

I couldn't stop thinking about the way he looked at me. The way he said my name. The way he made me feel.

My hand slipped between my legs almost of its own accord. I was still sensitive, still swollen, but the touch sent sparks through me anyway. I

thought about Aden's fingers replacing mine. His tongue. His cock stretching me open.

I bit my lip to keep from making sound, and immediately felt the rush of shame that had been missing before. Not for cheating on Terry. For getting myself off in our shower while thinking about his friend.

The shame felt good too. It felt like confirmation that I was someone new now, someone capable of things the old Brenna never would have done.

When I finally emerged from the bathroom in clean clothes with my wet hair hiding the mark on my neck, Terry had the pizza warmed and waiting. He queued up a show he knew I liked. He poured me a glass of wine. He was being the perfect, attentive boyfriend.

And all I could think about was when I'd see Aden again.

"You okay?" Terry asked as I picked at my pizza. "You seem distant."

"Just tired. It was a really long day."

"Aden working you too hard?"

The irony of the question almost made me laugh. "No. He's fine. I just covered for someone who called in sick. Double shift."

"That's nice of you." Terry put his arm around me and I let myself lean into him, testing how it felt. His body was familiar. Comfortable. Safe.

Boring, whispered a voice in my head that sounded dangerously like the new version of myself.

"How was your day?" I asked, trying to focus on being normal. Being the girlfriend he expected.

He launched into a story about his classes and I nodded in the right places and made appropriate sounds, but I wasn't really listening. I was thinking about my phone in my bag. About whether Aden would text. About what I'd say if he did.

My phone buzzed halfway through Terry's story.

"You should check that," Terry said. "Might be Aden about your schedule."

My heart jumped. I pulled out my phone trying to look casual. The message was from an unknown number.

It's Aden. Hope that's okay.

I stared at the screen, very aware of Terry sitting next to me.

What are you doing? Another message came through.

My fingers hovered over the keyboard. This was dangerous. Terry was right here. But the thrill of it, the wrongness, made my pulse quicken.

Watching TV with Terry I typed back.

Three dots appeared immediately. *Thinking about me?*

I glanced at Terry. He had gone back to his story, completely oblivious.

Maybe I sent.

I can't stop thinking about you. About what we did.

Heat flushed through me. My thighs pressed together under the blanket.

Me neither

When can I see you again?

My fingers were already typing: *I work Saturday*

The morning shift ends at 2. Can you stay after?

Terry's hand on my knee made me jump. "Everything okay?"

"Yeah." I locked my phone and set it face down. "Just Aden confirming my shift Saturday."

"You're working a lot lately. I barely see you anymore."

"I thought you wanted me to have this job. To get out more."

"I do. I just miss you." He kissed my temple. "But I'm glad it's going well. Aden says you're really good at it."

"He does?"

"Yeah. He texted me earlier saying you're a natural. That you're coming out of your shell." Terry squeezed my knee. "I knew this would be good for you."

I felt a spike of irritation. He gotten me the job to fix me. To turn me into someone less quiet, less withdrawn. Someone he thought would be better.

Aden didn't want to fix me. He wanted me exactly as I was. The quiet. The reserve. He saw it as something intriguing instead of something broken.

My phone buzzed again. I ignored it, but I could feel it there like a live wire against the couch cushion.

"I'm going to bed," I said, standing. "I'm exhausted."

"Want company?" Terry's hand slid up my thigh suggestively.

My stomach turned. The thought of him touching me now, after Aden, felt wrong. "I'm really tired, babe. Rain check?"

Disappointment flashed across his face but he nodded. "Sure. Get some rest."

In our bedroom I finally checked my phone.

Say yes. Please.

I typed back: *Yes*

Good. I'll make sure we're alone.

Another message came through: *I need to taste you again*

My breath caught. I glanced at the closed bedroom door, listening for any sign of Terry coming down the hall. When I heard nothing but the TV, I typed: *I need more than that*

Greedy girl

You made me this way

There was a pause. Then: *I know. And I'm not sorry.*

I sent: *What are you going to do to me Saturday?*

Everything. I'm going to fuck your brains out.

The words sent a bolt of heat straight through me. I bit my lip to keep from making a sound.

Promise?

I promise. Now go be a good girlfriend and stop texting me before you get caught.

It made me feel reckless. Powerful. I was doing something dangerous and getting away with it. Playing two roles at once and neither of them knew.

I set my phone on silent and climbed into bed. When Terry came in an hour later and curved his body around mine, his arm over my waist, I let him. I let him kiss my shoulder and whisper that he loved me.

"Love you too," I whispered back.

The lie came so easily it scared me.

The next few days passed in a strange fog. I went through the motions of being Terry's girlfriend. I made him breakfast. I laughed at his jokes. I let him hold my hand when we went out. But I felt like I was watching myself from outside my body, playing a part I no longer believed in.

The whole time I was counting down to Saturday.

Friday night Terry suggested we stay in and watch movies. "I feel like I haven't had you to myself in weeks," he said, pulling me close on the couch.

"I've been right here."

"I know. But you seem different lately. Distracted." He searched my face. "Is everything okay? With us?"

This was my chance. I could tell him the truth. End this before it got worse. Before the hurt became irreparable.

"Everything's fine," I said instead. "I'm just adjusting to the new schedule. It's tiring."

"Maybe you should cut back on shifts. You don't need to work that much."

"I like working." The words surprised me with their vehemence. "I like having something that's mine."

"Okay." He held up his hands. "I just want to make sure you're happy."

"I am." Another lie. But what was one more at this point?

He kissed me and I kissed him back, testing myself. His mouth was familiar. Safe. The kiss was sweet and gentle and everything it had always been.

It left me completely cold.

When he tried to take it further, sliding his hand under my shirt, I let him. Partially because saying no would raise questions. Partially because I was curious how it would feel now that I knew what it was like with Aden.

The sex was fine. Terry was gentle and considerate like always. He asked if I was okay. He checked in to make sure I was enjoying myself. He did all the things a good boyfriend should do.

But there was no urgency. No desperation. No sense that he'd die if he couldn't have me right that second.

When it was over and he pulled me against his chest, satisfied and content, I stared at the ceiling and felt nothing but impatience for tomorrow to come.

Saturday morning I woke up before my alarm. Terry was still asleep beside me, one arm thrown over his face, completely peaceful. I slipped out of bed carefully and went to the bathroom to get ready.

I took longer than usual. I shaved everywhere. I used the expensive body lotion I usually saved for special occasions. I put on makeup that looked natural but took twenty minutes to perfect. I told myself I was just taking pride in my appearance. That it had nothing to do with Aden seeing me in a few hours.

The lying was getting easier.

I dressed in the bathroom so I wouldn't wake Terry. I pulled on black jeans that fit just right and a top that was professional enough for work but low-cut enough to show the curve of my breasts when I bent forward. I'd bought new underwear during the week, lace and silk that made me feel powerful in a way my old cotton basics never had.

When I came out Terry was awake, scrolling his phone in bed.

"You look nice," he said, glancing up.

"Just work clothes."

"Since when do you wear makeup to make coffee?"

My heart skipped but I kept my voice casual. "I'm trying to look more professional. Aden mentioned maybe giving me more responsibility. Training me on inventory and ordering."

The lie came so smoothly I almost believed it myself.

"That's great, babe. See? I knew this job would be good for you." He smiled but all I felt was impatience for him to stop talking so I could leave.

"I should go. Don't want to be late."

"Text me when your shift ends. Maybe we can do lunch."

"Can't. Aden asked if I could stay after to learn the inventory system. Might be there until four or five."

Another lie. But this one I'd planned last night while Terry slept beside me. I'd texted Aden after Terry fell asleep: *Tell me we have until at least 5*

His response had been immediate: *I'll make sure of it*

Now Terry just nodded, completely trusting. "Okay. Dinner then. I'll cook."

"Sounds good." I kissed him quickly and left before he could see the anticipation in my eyes.

The drive to Driftwood felt electric. Every red light was torture. Every slow driver made me want to scream. By the time I pulled into the parking lot my hands were shaking.

Aden's car was already there. The cafe didn't open for another fifteen minutes. I let myself in through the back entrance with the key he'd given me during the week, another small trust that made the betrayal worse and somehow more thrilling.

He was in the office doing paperwork. When he looked up and saw me, something dark and hungry flashed across his face.

"You're early."

"So are you."

"Couldn't sleep." He stood, closing the distance between us. "Kept thinking about today."

"Me too."

His hand came up to cup my jaw, thumb brushing over my bottom lip. "You wore makeup."

"Wanted to look nice for you."

"You always look nice." His other hand settled on my hip, pulling me closer. "But I'd be lying if I said I wasn't picturing smudging it."

Heat flooded through me. "We should wait until after the shift."

"Should we?" His mouth was at my ear now, voice low and rough. "Or should I bend you over this desk right now?"

God, I wanted that. I wanted to say yes and let him take me right here before we even opened. But I pulled back, pleased when I saw the frustration in his eyes.

"After," I said firmly. "We can't risk someone showing up early. And I want time. Lots of time."

"Greedy girl."

"You like it."

"I do." He kissed me hard and quick, then stepped back. "But you're right. We should open. The sooner we get through the shift, the sooner I can have you."

The morning rush was torture. Every time our hands brushed passing drinks. Every time he said my name. Every time he leaned past me and I caught his scent. I was wound so tight I thought I might snap.

But I was also calculating. Watching the clock. Thinking ahead.

During a lull around eleven I pulled out my phone and texted Terry:
Aden wants me to stay until 6 actually. Inventory is more complicated than he thought. Sorry about dinner.

Terry's response came quickly: *No worries! I'll just order something. You're such a good employee, staying late with him like this*

The irony would have been funny if it wasn't so twisted.

Another text: *Aden's lucky to have you*

I glanced at Aden across the cafe, watched him make a latte for a customer, and typed back: *I'm lucky to have him*

At least that wasn't entirely a lie.

At one-thirty the other employee showed up for the closing shift, a girl named Maya who usually worked evenings. She tied on her apron and gave me a friendly smile.

"Hey Brenna. Aden said you're training on inventory today?"

"Yeah. Just observing."

"Cool. I can handle the floor if you guys need to be in the back."

Perfect. I'd suggested this to Aden via text earlier in the week, framing it as actually wanting to learn inventory. He caught on immediately and arranged Maya's shift to overlap.

Now we had a built-in excuse to disappear into the back for hours.

"Thanks Maya," Aden said. "Shout if you need us."

"Will do."

We went to the back office and Aden closed the door. The second it clicked shut he was on me, pushing me against the wall, his mouth hot and demanding on mine.

"Fuck, I've been dying to do that all morning," he muttered against my lips.

"Me too." My hands went to his belt but he caught them.

"Not yet."

"Why not?"

"Because I've been thinking about this all week and I'm not rushing." He pulled back to look at me, his eyes dark. "Take off your clothes."

The command sent a thrill through me. "Here? What if Maya..."

"She won't come back here unless we call her. Take them off. Slowly."

I did as he asked, maintaining eye contact as I pulled my shirt over my head. His gaze tracked every movement, hungry and appreciative. When I unhooked my bra and let it fall, his jaw tightened.

"New underwear?" he asked when I pushed my jeans down to reveal the lace beneath.

"Bought it this week. Just for you."

"For me?"

"Yes."

He sat down on the couch. "Come here."

I walked to him slowly, hyperaware of my near-nakedness, the power in being wanted this much. When I was close enough he pulled me onto his lap so I was straddling him.

"I've been thinking about something," he said, his hands sliding up my thighs.

"What?"

"Last week was rushed. We were both so worked up we couldn't wait." His thumbs hooked into my underwear. "Today I want to take my time. Learn every inch of you. Figure out exactly what makes you fall apart."

My breath caught. "We have until six."

"I know. I'm going to use every minute." He pulled my underwear down and I lifted my hips to help him. "By the time you leave here, you're going to forget that boyfriend of yours exists."

"I already have."

The confession made his eyes flash. "Have you?"

"Yes. When I'm with you, Terry doesn't exist. The apartment doesn't exist. My whole life doesn't exist. There's just this."

"Just us."

"Just us," I agreed.

He kissed me slower this time, deeper, like he had all the time in the world. His hands explored my body without urgency, relearning the landscape. When his fingers found me wet and ready, he pulled back with a satisfied smile.

"Already?"

"I've been thinking about this all week too."

"Tell me what you've been thinking about." His finger circled my clit lazily. "I want to know what gets you this wet."

"Your mouth," I gasped. "Your hands. The way you look at me like you can't get enough."

"I can't." He added another finger, working me slowly. "What else?"

"The risk. The wrongness of it." The confession tumbled out. "Knowing Terry trusts us both and we're betraying him. It should make me feel terrible but it just makes it hotter."

Something dark flashed in Aden's eyes. "You like being bad."

"I didn't know it until you."

"And now?"

"Now I can't stop." I rocked against his hand. "I don't want to stop. I want more."

"More of what?"

"Everything. I want to sneak around with you. I want to lie shamelessly to Terry. I want to come home smelling like your come and act like nothing happened." The words were spilling out now, admissions I hadn't even known I was thinking. "I want him to think I'm learning inventory while you're actually fucking me stupid. I want to sit across from him at dinner and know that hours earlier I was on my knees sucking you."

"Jesus, Brenna." His fingers worked faster. "You're going to kill me."

"Good." I kissed him hard. "I want you obsessed with me. I want you thinking about me when you shouldn't. I want to be the thing you can't have but take anyway."

"You already are."

I grinned on his fingers with his name on my lips, and when I came down I was already planning our next time. Already thinking about how to carve out more hours. More excuses. More opportunities to be this version of myself.

The version that was coming alive in the worst possible way.

I pulled back to look at Aden, my chest still heaving. His fingers were still inside me, and when he slowly withdrew them I felt the loss acutely.

"We have hours," I said, my voice steady. "I want to use all of them."

"What did you have in mind?"

I climbed off his lap and knelt between his legs, my hands already working his belt. "I want you to teach me what you like. I want to know exactly how to make you lose control." I looked up at him through my lashes. "I want to be better at this than I've ever been with him."

The comparison made Aden's breath catch. "You want to compete with your boyfriend?"

"No." I freed him from his jeans, wrapping my hand around him. "I want to ruin you for anyone else the way you're ruining me for him."

What followed was slow and consuming. We used every surface in that office. The couch. The desk. The wall. Aden mapped every inch of my body with his mouth and hands, finding spots that made me gasp that I hadn't known existed. I learned what made him groan, what made his control slip, what made him say my name like a prayer.

By the time we finally collapsed on the couch, sweaty and spent, hours had passed. The cafe sounds from beyond the door had long since quieted as Maya handled the few evening customers alone.

"I should check on Maya," Aden said eventually, not moving.

"In a minute." I traced patterns on his chest. "I don't want this to end yet."

"It doesn't have to." His arm tightened around me. "We can do this again. As often as you want."

"I want it all the time."

"So we'll find ways. You're good at making excuses already." He tilted my chin up to look at him. "How did you get so good at lying?"

"I learned from necessity." I kissed him softly.

"You're not going to break up with him, are you?"

The question hung between us. The answer came easily.

"No."

Aden nodded slowly. "Good."

"Good?"

"If you broke up with him, everyone would know something happened. They would ask questions. People would speculate." His hand slid down my spine. "This way, you're still his sweet, quiet girlfriend. And I get to know the real you. The one who comes apart in my arms and lies about it so well no one suspects."

"You like that I'm lying to him."

"I like that you're mine in secret." He rolled us so he was above me. "I like that he thinks you're learning inventory while you're actually learning how to take my cock deeper. I like that you'll go home tonight and kiss him and he won't know you can still taste me."

His words sent heat through me again even though I was exhausted.

"We're terrible people."

"I know." He kissed me slowly. "Does that bother you?"

I thought about it honestly. I thought about Terry at home, probably cooking dinner right now, completely oblivious. I thought about the life I was supposed to want with him, the safe, comfortable future we'd planned, meeting his parents for lunch, talking about buying new furniture.

Then I thought about how I felt right here, right now. Alive. Desired. Free from being someone's project.

"No," I said finally. "It doesn't bother me at all."

I got home at six-thirty. Terry was in the kitchen making pasta, exactly as he'd said he would. He was so reliable like that. He looked up when I walked in and smiled that trusting smile.

"Hey babe. How was inventory?"

"Complicated." I set my bag down, hyperaware of my body, of the evidence I carried. "But I think I'm getting the hang of it."

"That's great. You must be exhausted."

"I am." I walked to him and kissed his cheek, testing myself. His familiar scent surrounded me and I felt nothing but mild affection. It was the kind you'd feel for an old friend.

"Go shower. Dinner will be ready in ten."

In the bathroom I looked at myself in the mirror. My makeup was smudged just like Aden had promised. My lips were swollen. There were new marks on my neck I'd have to hide. My hair was messy.

I looked so thoroughly fucked. And I loved it.

I showered quickly and changed into comfortable clothes, hiding the evidence. When I came out Terry had dinner done. We sat across from each other like we had a thousand times before.

"I was thinking," he said between bites. "Maybe next weekend we could go hiking. You've been working so much, we should do something outside together."

"That sounds nice."

"And I wanted to tell you, I'm really proud of you. For putting yourself out there with this job. I can see the difference in you already. You seem more confident. More alive."

The irony was so perfect I almost laughed. "Thank you for pushing me to do it."

"That's what I'm here for. To help you be your best self."

My phone buzzed on the table. It was a text from Aden.

"Work?" Terry asked.

"Probably." I rolled my eyes at him and picked it up casually. "Just checking the schedule for next week."

The message read: *Already missing you. Wednesday?*

I typed back under the table: *Yes. I'll figure out an excuse.*

Terry kept talking about the hike, about his classes, about mundane things that used to be my whole world. I nodded and smiled and responded appropriately while planning my lies for Wednesday.

I'd tell Terry I needed to cover a morning shift. I would leave early and come home late. I would probably fuck Aden in that office again and come home to kiss Terry like nothing happened.

"You okay?" Terry asked. "You seem distracted again."

"Just tired." I reached across the table and took his hand, the gesture automatic. "But I'm good. Really good."

The terrible truth was, I meant it. I was good. Better than I'd been in years. I'd found something that made me feel alive, even if it was built on lies and betrayal. Even if it was wrong in every possible way.

I'd found a version of myself I didn't know existed. I found in myself someone who could deceive and scheme and take what she wanted without

apology. I was someone who could compartmentalize her guilt and bury it under the thrill of being wildly desired.

Terry squeezed my hand and smiled, completely unaware that the woman sitting across from him wasn't the same person who he set up with his friend to work in his cafe. She'd never be that person again. He got exactly what he hoped for.

I smiled back and thought about what I'd wear to surprise Aden on Wednesday.